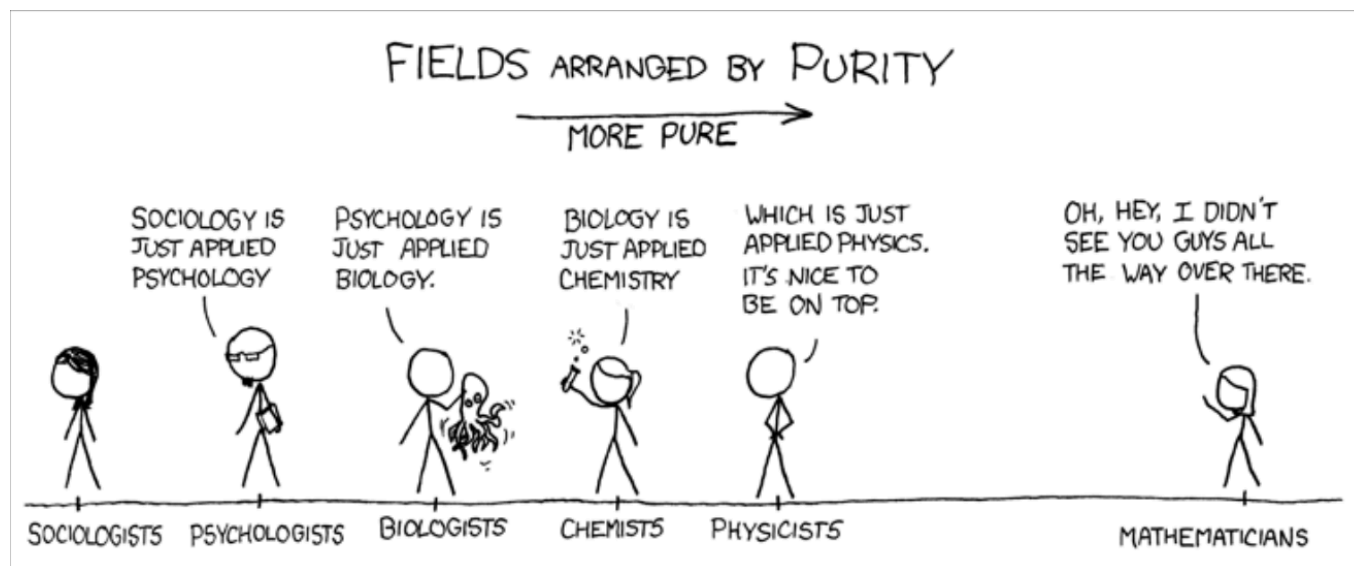


The Ladder

You sent a mystical diagram and a joke about scientists. They are drawing the same thing, and the disagreement between them is the interesting part. This explains both in plain language, and what the older one knows that the funnier one leaves out.

01 Same picture

You sent two pictures. They are the same picture.



xkcd 435, Purity. Randall Munroe, 2008. CC BY-NC 2.5.

- A joke about scientists. Sociology is applied psychology is applied biology is applied chemistry is applied physics.
- Then the mathematician is standing so far away nobody had noticed.

The other is a diagram from Kabbalah (a Jewish mystical tradition, roughly 800 years old in written form). Same claim, no joke. Reality is a stack, and each level down is the one above made heavier.

THE ONE IDEA

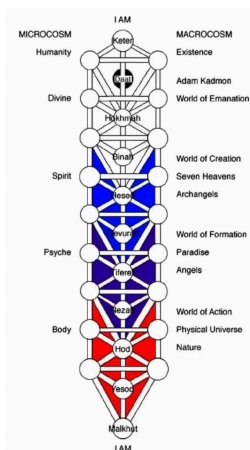
Both pictures say reality comes in layers, and each layer is the one above it made denser. The comic finds that funny. The diagram finds it holy. Neither disagrees about the shape.

02 The stack

The tradition splits the stack into four levels. Think of building a house.

- **Emanation** (Atzilut). The house exists as a wish. Nothing is decided.
- **Creation** (Beriah). Somebody decides to build a house. Still no house.
- **Formation** (Yetzirah). The blueprint. Rooms, measurements, where the door goes.
- **Action** (Assiah). Bricks. The house you can stand in.

Same house at every stage. What changes is how much of it you can touch. Your diagram stacks four of these on top of each other, which is why it is so tall, and that extended form is called **Jacob's Ladder** after the dream in Genesis.



The Jacob's Ladder form. Microcosm left, macrocosm right. Source unverified.

The circles are the ten **sephirot** (stages reality passes through). **Keter** at the top is crown, pure possibility. **Malkhut** at the bottom is kingdom, the world you are sitting in. Between them run pairs that balance each other, wisdom against understanding, kindness against restraint, endurance against yielding, with **Tiferet**, beauty, holding the middle.

Daat (knowledge) is the black one. It is drawn hollow because it is not counted among the ten.

03 Both ends

Here is the part the comic misses, and it is the reason the diagram is worth your time.

- Look at the top of the tree. It says **I AM**.
- Now look at the bottom. It says **I AM** again.
- The ladder does not end at either end. It closes.

The comic ranks the layers, and the mathematician wins by standing furthest from anything real. Funny, a little bit true, and useless.

The diagram refuses the ranking. The most abstract level and the most physical one are given the same name on purpose. **Nobody has ever lived in a blueprint**. The house is the point, and the house is made of bricks.

THE TAKEAWAY

Both pictures draw reality as a stack. The comic says the top is best. The diagram says the top and the bottom are the same word, and only one of them keeps the rain off.

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: xkcd 435, Purity, Randall Munroe, 2008, xkcd.com/435, CC BY-NC 2.5; The four worlds and the ten sephirot are standard in Kabbalistic literature. The house analogy is the tradition's own teaching device; The microcosm and macrocosm form is associated with twentieth century writers on Kabbalah. The artist of this rendering is UNVERIFIED.

Kabbalah is a living tradition. What it teaches is reported as what it teaches, not asserted as fact. Personal study only, not for publication.